Today, every inhabitant of this planet must contemplate the day when this planet may no longer be habitable. Every man, woman and child lives under a nuclear sword of Damocles, hanging by the slenderest of threads, capable of being cut at any moment by accident or miscalculation or by madness.

—JOHN F. KENNEDY, SEPTEMBER 1961[1]

Of course, I was scared. It would have been insane not to be scared, I was frightened about what could happen to my country and all the countries that would be devastated by a nuclear war. If being frightened meant that I helped avert such insanity, then I'm glad I was frightened. One of the problems in the world today is that not enough people are sufficiently frightened by danger of nuclear war.

—NIKITA KHRUSHCHEV, DECEMBER 1962[2]